

Stalkerware

How hidden monitoring apps work, how to check your own phone, and how to help someone who is being watched.

NAME _____
LESSON 17 • 90 MIN

BEFORE YOU START

- Each task shows its time, how you work, and what to post in the chat. Tasks marked + **Extra** are for when you finish early.
- Don't know a word? Look in the Key words box, then use a translator or a dictionary.
- Post only what a task asks for. Never post passwords, phone numbers or private messages.

What is stalkerware?

8 MIN • ALONE • READ, THEN TASK 1

stalkerware	an app that secretly watches another person's phone	consent	permission: the person knows about it and says yes
monitor	to watch and record what someone does	permission	a setting that lets an app use something, e.g. the location or the microphone
hidden	difficult to see or find	account	your login for a service, e.g. a Google Account or an Apple Account

Stalkerware is an app that one person secretly installs on another person's phone to watch them. The app sends data to the person who installed it: text messages, call history, photos, the phone's location, and sometimes the microphone and everything the owner types. The person reads this data on a website, so they never need to touch the phone again.

Often, the person is a partner or an ex-partner. On an Android phone, they usually need the phone and the PIN for a few minutes. Stalkerware is not in the official app store, so they install it from a file, and they often switch off Google Play Protect first. On an iPhone, they sometimes need only the email and password of the owner's Apple Account, not the phone. Two-factor authentication makes this much harder.

The app tries to stay hidden. It often has no icon, or a plain name like “System Service” or “Sync”. The owner may never notice it.

Stalkerware is not the same as a work-phone app or a normal parental-control app. Those apps are visible, and the people who use the phone know about them. But some stalkerware is sold as a “parental-control” app, with a hidden mode. In many countries, installing monitoring software on another adult's phone without permission is a crime.

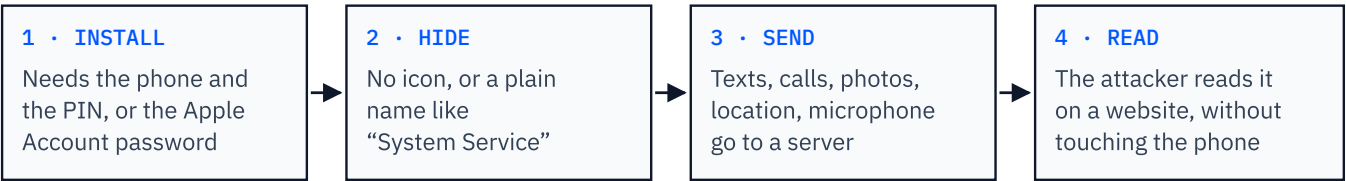


FIGURE 1 – HOW STALKERWARE WORKS

Task 1 — True, false, or not in the text

5 MIN · ALONE · POST IN CHAT: 1 T, 2 F, ...

Tick **T** (true), **F** (false) or **NG** (the text does not say). Find the sentence in the text that gives your answer.

#	Statement	T	F	NG
1	Stalkerware can send the location of a phone to another person.	☐	☐	☐
2	Stalkerware is usually installed from the official app store.	☐	☐	☐
3	On Android, the person usually needs the phone and the PIN to install it.	☐	☐	☐
4	On an iPhone, someone can sometimes get data without touching the phone.	☐	☐	☐
5	Stalkerware always has an icon on the screen.	☐	☐	☐
6	A normal work-phone app is hidden from the people who use the phone.	☐	☐	☐
7	The text says how many people have stalkerware on their phone.	☐	☐	☐

+ **EXTRA** What is the main difference between stalkerware and a parental-control app? Write one sentence.

Task 2 — Is it stalkerware?

10 MIN · ALONE, THEN COMPARE IN CHAT · POST: A, B, C, D AND YES OR NO

Tick **Y** (yes) or **N** (no) in each column. Stalkerware is hidden, and the owner does not know about it and did not agree.

	Situation	Owner knows?	App visible?	Owner agreed?	Stalkerware?
A	A company installs a management app on its phones. The employees sign a policy, and the app is in the app list.	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N
B	A parent and their 15-year-old agree to share locations. The app is on the teenager's home screen.	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N
C	A man installs an app without an icon on his girlfriend's phone. She does not know.	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N
D	Anna and Tom shared their locations for two years. They break up. Tom does not turn sharing off. Anna forgot that it is still on.	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N	☐ Y ☐ N

Situation D — discuss in the chat

- Is Tom's sharing stalkerware? Give a reason in one sentence.
- What should Anna do?

+ **EXTRA** A parent installs a hidden app on a 14-year-old's phone. Is that acceptable? Give one reason.

Task 3 — Count the red flags

12 MIN · ALONE · POST IN CHAT: APP NAMES AND FLAG NUMBERS

Below is the app list of a phone. The apps are fictional. For each app, count the red flags from the box and write the number in the last column. Then answer a) and b).

Flag	The app has a red flag if ...
F1	Source: it was installed from a file (APK), not from Google Play.
F2	Icon: it has no icon on the home screen.
F3	Name: it sounds like part of the phone's system, e.g. "System Service", "Update", "Sync", "Device Health".
F4	Permissions: they do not match the app's job. A calculator that reads SMS is a red flag. No job listed is also a red flag.
F5	Special access: it has Accessibility, Device admin or Notification access.

0 flags: normal. **1 flag:** check the permissions. **2 or more:** investigate.

#	App	Its job	Source	Icon	Permissions and special access	Flags
1	Maps	Maps and navigation	Google Play	yes	Location, Notifications	
2	Quick Calculator	Calculator	Google Play	yes	Location, Microphone, SMS	
3	WhatsApp	Messaging	Google Play	yes	Contacts, Microphone, Camera, Notifications	
4	Wi-Fi Helper	Finds Wi-Fi networks	File (APK)	yes	Location, Notification access	
5	Music Player	Plays your music files	Google Play	yes	Notifications	
6	System Service	—	File (APK)	no	Location, SMS, Call logs, Microphone, Accessibility, Device admin	
7	Pocket Bank	Banking and payments	Google Play	yes	Camera, Notifications	
8	Weather	Weather forecast	Google Play	yes	Location, Notifications	

a) Which app has the most flags? _____

b) Which apps have 2 or more flags? _____

+ **EXTRA** Quick Calculator has 1 flag. What would you do with it?

Task 4 — Check your own phone

25 MIN · ON YOUR OWN PHONE · POST IN CHAT: SYSTEM, CHECKS DONE, CHECKS TO LOOK AT

Choose the table for your phone. Open each place and tick **OK** or **Look** (something you do not know). Menu names depend on the brand and version. If you cannot find a place, type the key word in the search bar of Settings.

Android

OK	Look	Where to go	What to look for
☐	☐	Google Play → profile icon → Play Protect → Scan	Play Protect is on. The scan finds no harmful app.
☐	☐	Settings → Apps → See all apps	Names you do not know, or plain names like “System Service”.
☐	☐	Settings → Accessibility → Downloaded apps	An app you did not install or do not use.
☐	☐	Settings → Security → Device admin apps	Any app you do not know. For most people the list is empty.
☐	☐	Settings → Apps → Special app access → Install unknown apps	An app that is “Allowed” and you do not know why.
☐	☐	Settings → Apps → Special app access → Notification read, reply & control	An app you do not know. A smartwatch app is normal.

iPhone

OK	Look	Where to go	What to look for
☐	☐	Settings → Privacy & Security → Safety Check → Manage Sharing & Access	People or apps that can see your location or data, and you do not know them.
☐	☐	Settings → your name → scroll down	A device in the list that is not yours.
☐	☐	Settings → your name → Sign-In & Security	Two-Factor Authentication is on.
☐	☐	Settings → General → VPN & Device Management	A profile you do not know. No “Profiles” section is fine.
☐	☐	Settings → Apps, or swipe left to the App Library	Apps you do not know.
☐	☐	Find My app → People	People who can see your location, and you do not know why.

Post like this: “Android – 6 checks, 1 to look at.” Do not write the names of apps or people.

If you find something: do not delete it yet. Go to Task 5. If you find nothing, the phone is not proven clean: good stalkerware is hard to see. These checks find the common cases.

No phone with you? On your computer, open myaccount.google.com → Security → **Your devices**, then Security → **Third-party apps & services**. Post three numbers: devices, devices you do not know, apps you do not use any more.

Task 5 — Help a friend

15 MIN · ALONE · POST IN CHAT: A) FIVE LETTERS, B) YOUR MESSAGE

Your friend sends you this message.

MESSAGE FROM YOUR FRIEND

I think my ex is watching my phone. Yesterday he knew where I was and I didn't tell him.
I want to delete all my apps and reset the phone tonight. What should I do?

a) Which 5 actions are good advice? Tick them.

- A ☐ Reset the phone tonight, and then tell him you know.
- B ☐ Use a different phone or computer, one he has never used, to look for help.
- C ☐ Keep evidence: write down app names and dates before you delete anything.
- D ☐ Ask him if he installed something on the phone.
- E ☐ Contact a support organisation or the police. stopstalkerware.org lists organisations by country.
- F ☐ From the safe device, change the password of your email and your Google or Apple account, and turn on two-factor authentication.
- G ☐ Do not message anyone about it or search for stalkerware on the watched phone.
- H ☐ Install a free “spy detector” from a random website.

b) Write your reply to your friend in the chat.

4 to 6 sentences. Use the 5 actions you chose and say why: “... because ...”.

USEFUL LANGUAGE

First, ... Then, ... After that, ... Don't ... yet Use ... to ...
If you feel unsafe, because ...

Task 6 — Your next step

3 MIN · ALONE · POST IN CHAT: “THIS WEEK I WILL ...”

Choose one thing you will really do this week.

- ☐ turn on two-factor authentication on my main account.
- ☐ delete the apps I do not use and check the permissions of the others.
- ☐ show a friend how to do the checks from Task 4.
- ☐ check the device list in my Google Account or Apple Account.
- ☐ change my phone PIN to one that nobody knows.

Optional — the news report

12 MIN • AT HOME, OR IN CLASS IF THERE IS TIME • POST IN CHAT: YOUR ANSWERS

ABC News, “Stalkerware” (3 min 15 s): [youtube.com/watch?v=CVTRcr8xwL4](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CVTRcr8xwL4)

Read the questions first. Then watch twice.

covertly	in secret, so that nobody sees	exfiltrate	to take data out of a device in secret
circumvent	to find a way around a rule	stealth mode	a setting that makes an app invisible

1. Which of these does the report say stalkerware can see or collect? Tick all that apply.

☐ the phone's location

☐ the phone's battery level

☐ text messages

☐ emails on a laptop

☐ phone calls

☐ passwords

☐ websites you visit

☐ everything you type

2. Who often installs stalkerware, say the experts?

☐ a boss ☐ a friend ☐ an intimate partner ☐ a stranger on the internet

3. How long did the expert need to install it on the Android phone?

☐ a few seconds ☐ a few minutes ☐ a few hours

4. The reporter looks through her phone. What does she find?

☐ the app, with a clear icon ☐ no app that she does not recognise ☐ a warning message

5. Eva Galperin says you can do the same things without fooling the person. Complete her next sentence.

“It can be done _____ consent.”

6. What should parental monitoring apps never do, according to Eva Galperin?

☐ work in stealth mode ☐ show an icon ☐ send messages

7. At the end, the report gives three tips. Which phone is each tip for? Tick one box in each row.

Tip	Android or computer	iPhone	Every phone
Always have a password on your phone.	☐	☐	☐
Run an antivirus scanner.	☐	☐	☐
Use the built-in security check.	☐	☐	☐

+ **EXTRA** Eva Galperin says that anything legitimate can be done with consent. Do you agree? Give one reason.